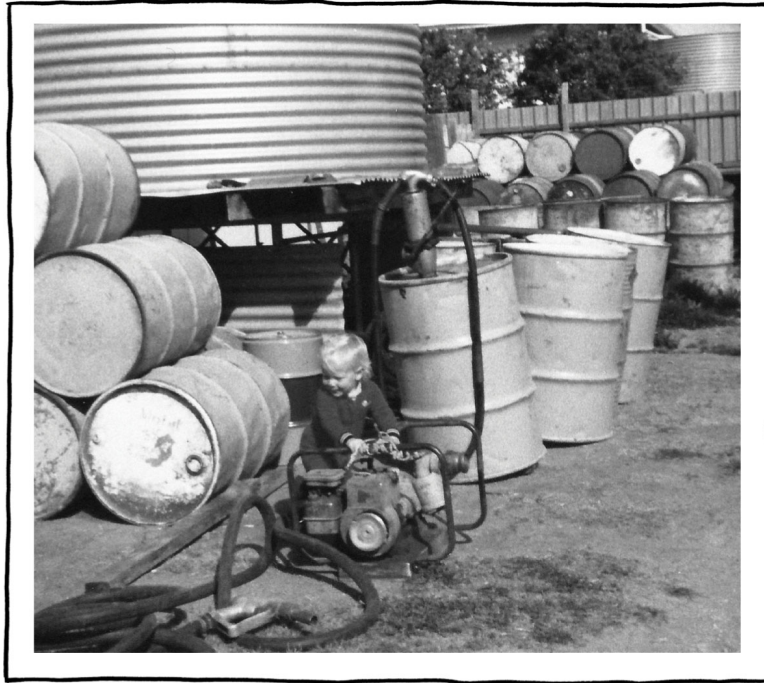


Yes, I grew up in another era. An era before helicopter parenting, tiger mumming and free-range fathering. Flipping through our family photo albums one day, I found this gem:

Is this a potential petrohazard . . . or a photo opportunity?



The author, aged 18 months, in Ouyen

Yes, I'm in a (red) jumpsuit.

Yes, my itty-bitsy fingers are poking around a live, hot, rusty old petrol pump.

Yes, the barrels of petrol—stacked three high—appear to be held only by a single plank of wood.

‘Say cheese, Scotty!’

(Contrast this to my kids, who aren't allowed outside unless they're wearing a wide-brimmed hat, a long-sleeve shirt, protective sunglasses and SPF-100 lathered head to toe. Because the sun is DANGEROUS.)

That's basically the story of my childhood.